The Holy Grail of Baseball Cards Is Up for Auction

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One of the most famous baseball cards in history is up for **auction**. Bidding has already passed $1 million, and there are still days left to go.

The card shows Honus Wagner and was made between 1909 and 1911. Its full official name is very long, but Heritage **Auctions** has a simpler nickname for it: the **Holy Grail** of baseball cards. A **holy grail** is something that people search for and want very badly.

Chris Ivy, who leads sports **auctions** at Heritage, called the T206 Wagner card the foundational trophy of baseball card collecting.

Honus Wagner is still one of baseball's most respected players. He was the son of a German **immigrant** who worked as a coal miner. Wagner, nicknamed the Flying Dutchman, played **shortstop** for the Pittsburgh Pirates from 1900 to 1917. He won eight batting titles. In 1937, he became one of the first players chosen for the Baseball **Hall of Fame** in Cooperstown, New York.

So why is his card so rare? Long ago, collectible cards came with tobacco products. Legend says Wagner told the company to stop printing cards with his picture after learning they were being used to sell cigarettes. Because so few of his cards were made, **collectors** want them very much.

This card is only the sixth T206 Wagner ever sold by Heritage **Auctions**. The bid stood at $1,025,000, and bidding runs until October 25. The sellers expect the card to sell for at least $3 million.

That might sound like a lot, but earlier this year, a similar Honus Wagner card from the same years sold for more than $5.8 million.

Word Treasure

auction -- A sale where people bid against each other and the highest offer wins.
Holy Grail -- Something people search for and want very badly.
immigrant -- A person who moves to a new country to live there.
shortstop -- A baseball player who plays between second and third base.
collectors -- People who gather and keep special items, like cards or coins.
Hall of Fame -- A place that honors the greatest people in a sport or field.

Background you need

Baseball cards are small printed cards showing players, and people have collected and traded them for more than a century.

A card's value depends on how rare it is, how famous the player is and what condition the card is in.

At an auction, buyers place higher and higher bids until time runs out, and the highest bidder wins the item.

Honus Wagner's cards from the early 1900s are especially rare because very few were printed, which is why collectors prize them so much.

Break it down

LEAD: A famous Honus Wagner baseball card is up for auction
KEY EVENT: Bidding has passed $1 million
+- WHO: Heritage Auctions, which calls it the Holy Grail of baseball cards
+- WHEN: Bidding runs until October 25
PLAYER: Wagner played shortstop for the Pittsburgh Pirates and joined the Hall of Fame in 1937
WHY RARE: Legend says he stopped the printing because cards were used to sell cigarettes
EVIDENCE: A similar card sold for more than $5.8 million earlier this year
OPEN QUESTION: How high will the final bid go?

Why it matters

The card shows how a small piece of sports history can become hugely valuable when it is rare and tied to a legendary player.

Test what you remember

1. Which player is shown on the famous card?

(A) Honus Wagner
(B) Babe Ruth
(C) Jackie Robinson
(D) Chris Ivy

2. When was the card made?

(A) In 1937
(B) Between 1909 and 1911
(C) Earlier this year
(D) In 1900

3. Which team did Wagner play shortstop for?

(A) The Chicago Cubs
(B) The Boston Red Sox
(C) The New York Yankees
(D) The Pittsburgh Pirates

4. According to legend, why are so few of his cards around?

(A) A fire destroyed them
(B) Wagner asked the company to stop printing them because they were used to sell cigarettes
(C) Collectors threw them away
(D) They were printed only in Germany

5. How much do the sellers expect the card to sell for?

(A) At least $3 million
(B) Exactly $5.8 million
(C) Less than $100,000
(D) About $1,000

6. When does bidding end?

(A) Next year
(B) October 25
(C) December 31
(D) October 1

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: D 4: B 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Chris Ivy, Heritage Auctions: Calls the T206 Wagner card the foundational trophy of baseball card collecting.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):